enormous variety of phenomena, made questioning its foundations an even more uncomfortable task. As J. J. C. Smart had noted (see the end of Chapter 8), it was unreasonable to expect purely philosophical arguments against the Copenhagen interpretation to sway the vast majority of physicists in reevaluating the philosophical foundations of such a successful theory. Arguments for an alternative interpretation would be needed as well. But most physicists were still convinced that alternatives to Copenhagen were impossible—Bell's detailed takedown of von Neumann's proof wasn't well-known yet. There was also the suspicion that quantum foundations wasn't "real" physics, because it was entirely removed from experimental work. Bell had shown this wasn't true either, but recognition of this fact was also slow. And until that recognition was wider, careers suffered—especially those of young physicists. Zeh and Clauser pursued work in quantum foundations despite constant discouragement, but they had done that work only after safely earning a PhD. Many physicists who were interested in such questions were discouraged from pursuing them even earlier in their careers—and those who didn't listen paid a price.

David Albert was a physics PhD student at Rockefeller University, in New York City, in the late 1970s. Albert had always been interested in philosophy, and one night early in graduate school, he was up at four in the morning reading a book by the philosopher David Hume when the true gravity of the quantum measurement problem hit him with full force. Thinking about Hume "somehow made it vivid that what happens to the wave function during a measurement ought to be a straightforward mechanical consequence of the Schrödinger equation, and not something that requires a separate postulate," he recalled. "It became very vivid to me that this isn't going to work, and this was the moment when I understood the measurement problem.… This night changed my life. I said, OK, that's what I want to work on. I want to work on the measurement problem."

None of the physicists at Rockefeller worked on the foundations of quantum physics, so Albert wasn't sure how to proceed. "There was nobody to talk to at Rockefeller. [A friend] said why don't you write to Aharonov? He was the only person people could think of at the time in physics, and I had no idea anybody was interested in these things in philosophy." Albert sent a letter off to Aharonov, who was in Israel at the time, without having met him—and Aharonov replied. "He was very generous to me," Albert